

EDUCATIONPLUS

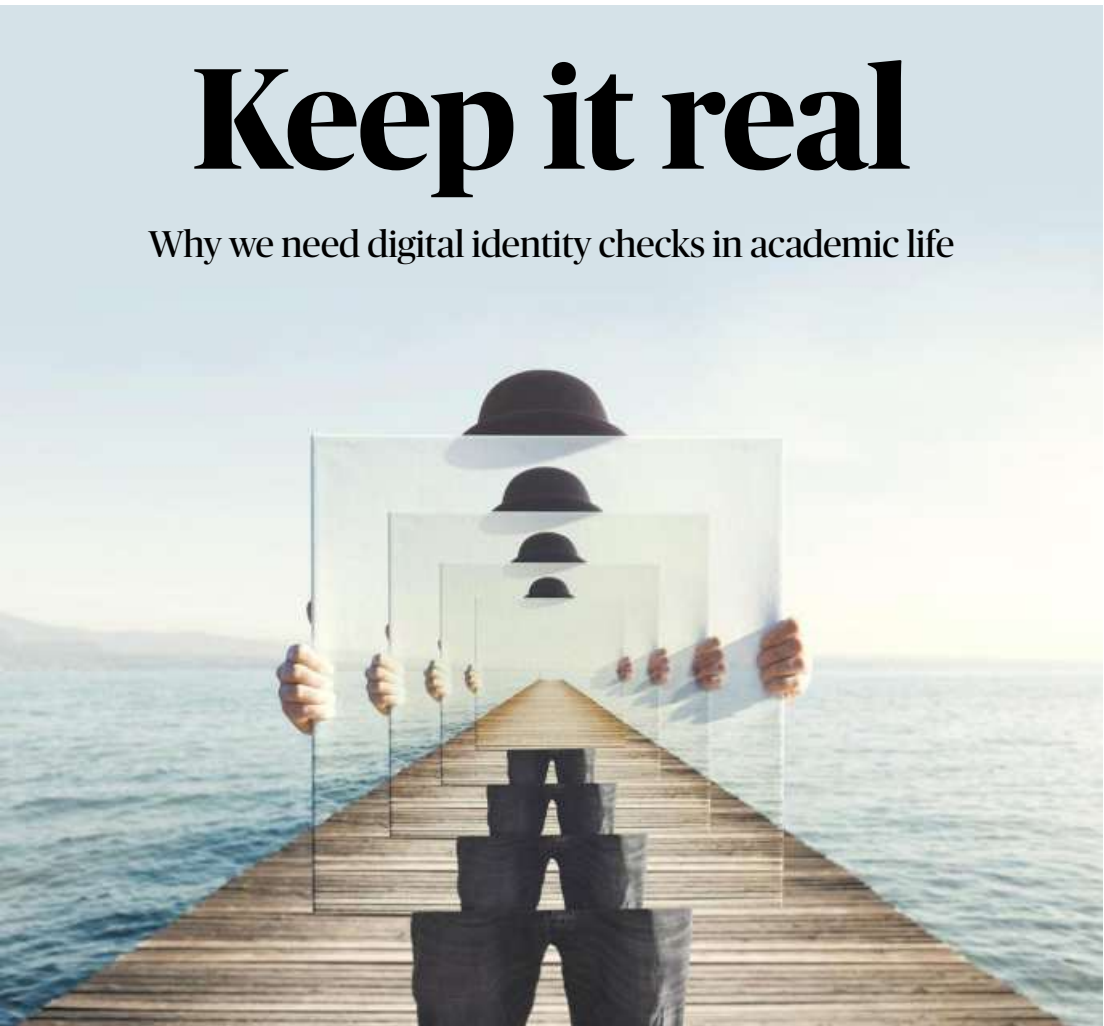
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Biju Dharmapalan

In an age where a researcher's reputation is often built – and judged – online before a single conversation takes place, the integrity of one's digital academic identity has become as critical as the research itself. Before a paper is read or a conversation begins, a quick online search often defines first impressions. Yet, the systems designed to track scholarly output are increasingly failing to present a coherent and accurate picture of researchers. This raises an urgent question: Do we need systematic digital identity checks to prevent private digital mismatching of academic profiles? The answer is an unequivocal yes.

Academic databases and professional platforms like ORCID (Open Researcher and Contributor ID), Scopus, LinkedIn, and others were designed to clarify scholarly contributions. Instead, they frequently generate a labyrinth of redundant profiles, misattributed publications, and incongruous affiliations. What was intended to improve visibility is, paradoxically, compromising accuracy.

Digital mismatch
Digital identity ambiguity often begins innocuously. While platforms



such as ORCID, LinkedIn, and indexing databases and preprint servers all go to some lengths to distinguish between researchers who share the same name, they update according to their own schedules and have a variety of rules for their users. Even on a single platform, some details are captured more reliably than others. Scopus, for instance, re-

ceives information from the journals that it indexes but the author profiles it produces do not always reflect a complete affiliation history. Occasionally, when a researcher changes their institution or affiliation, they neglect to update their profile. Over time, these distortions emerge as major issues in the profiling of researchers. In today's

academic environment, driven by metrics, discrepancies are not merely technical errors; they shape how researchers are perceived. There is a common perception that digital technologies facilitate easy verification. But a simple name search can yield numerous profiles and, in the absence of a standardised identity or coherent metadata, dif-

ferentiating one individual from another is a challenge. Even seasoned evaluators may find it difficult to ascertain which profile accurately reflects the “authentic” researcher. Thus, an increase in data does not inherently lead to enhanced comprehension.

Identity checks
Digital identity verification guarantees that the

online version of a researcher's academic trajectory is accurately represented. Moreover, it reinstates the individual's autonomy within a system that frequently operates outside their immediate supervision. Three pragmatic measures can markedly enhance digital coherence:

An updated ORCID profile: Most researchers have a unique ORCID throughout their lifetime. Even when a researcher changes affiliation, this remains the same. The profile should be linked to PURE and Scopus. Keeping affiliations and research output up to date makes one's ORCID page a stable reference point. Moreover, including the ORCID identifier when submitting papers allows publishers to add work to your record once it is published.

Institutional profile: Linking ORCID with institutional systems like PURE or the Indian Research Information Network System (IRINS) allows verified data such as publications and affiliations to be synchronised automatically.

Audit external platforms: Regularly checking profiles in databases such as Scopus, Web of Science, and Google Scholar helps identify duplicates, correct misattributions, and merge fragmented records.

Although personal attention is crucial, academic institutions, publishers, and database providers must collaborate to develop interoperable systems that mitigate fragmentation. Standardised IDs, enhanced integration across platforms, and proactive error-detection methods ought to be standard practice rather than anomalies.

A researcher's digital identity influences visibility, credibility, and opportunity. In contrast to a conventional CV, which is meticulously crafted and fixed, a digital profile is fluid, broadly available, and frequently outside direct oversight. This also serves as a lasting documentation of a career, referenced by future partners, institutions, and historians of science. Ensuring its truth transcends personal advantage; it pertains to academic honesty. As the quantity of academic data proliferates, the likelihood of misrepresentation currently increases. The resolution resides in awareness, regular maintenance, and structural reform, as your profile speaks for you, not just your study.

The writer is the Dean - Academic Affairs, Garden City University, Bengaluru, and an adjunct faculty at the National Institute of Advanced Studies, Bengaluru. E-mail: bijudharmapalan@gmail.com

SCHOLARSHIPS

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Rewards: Up to ₹12,000 (based on actual expenses) and mentorship
Application: Online
Deadline: August 20
www.b4s.in/edge/MKSP3

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Manage time wisely

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

and then speed. Analyse every mistake carefully.

I am preparing for the Civil Services along with a Master's. The preparation for CSE is overwhelming and I also have arrears. Please help me. Sriya

Dear Sriya,

Feeling overwhelmed is common among UPSC aspirants. Shift your focus to taking small, actionable steps. First print out the UPSC syllabus and mark off completed topics. This can motivate you to be consistent.

Use one standard book per subject, one monthly magazine, and one newspaper. Avoid collecting too much material. Spend 70% of your daily study time on current topics to prevent new backlogs and 30% on old ones. Use the first half of Sunday to clear the most important backlog and keep it a no-new-topic day.

For backlogs, read class handouts first and watch videos only for difficult sections. Maintain consistency, even on difficult days. When your Master's workload is high, commit to reading the newspaper and solving five MCQs to keep your UPSC preparation active.

Understand that your day has to be divided between sleep, studies, and personal life. If your Master's takes five hours, you may have three hours for UPSC. Accept this and use it wisely. If your Master's subject matches your UPSC Optional (such as History, Geography, or Sociology), use university resources to reduce your UPSC workload and improve your writing for Mains.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

offers free or subsidised training in solar panel installation, electrical work, and digital literacy.

I am in the third year of the five-year Law course. I want to be a company secretary but am afraid of failure. I am wondering if I should do an LLM. But I am sure that I want to work in the corporate sector. What should I do next? Bhumi

Dear Bhumi,

Both LLM and CS are valuable for corporate law but serve different roles. A Company Secretary focuses on compliance and governance and ensures that companies follow the Companies Act, SEBI norms, and Board procedures. The demand is high, as every listed company requires a CS.

An LLM focuses on deep legal research, complex litigation, or niche areas like IP and Taxation. It adds prestige and specialisation, especially from a top global university. However, companies often value law firm experience more than a domestic LLM.

The CS pass rate is low but, as a Law student, you can skip CSEET and enter the Executive Level. Around 60–70% of the CS syllabus is law-based, with tax and financial management being the main challenges.

Enrol for CS Executive now. You can make significant progress by graduation, and having CS (Executive) or CS (Finalist) on your CV can strengthen your placement prospects. Focus on Company Law, Securities Law, and Drafting.

Pursue an LLM only from a top global university or a leading NLU for Corporate Law. Focus on internships in in-house legal departments of MNCs or top corporate law firms and highlight your CS journey.

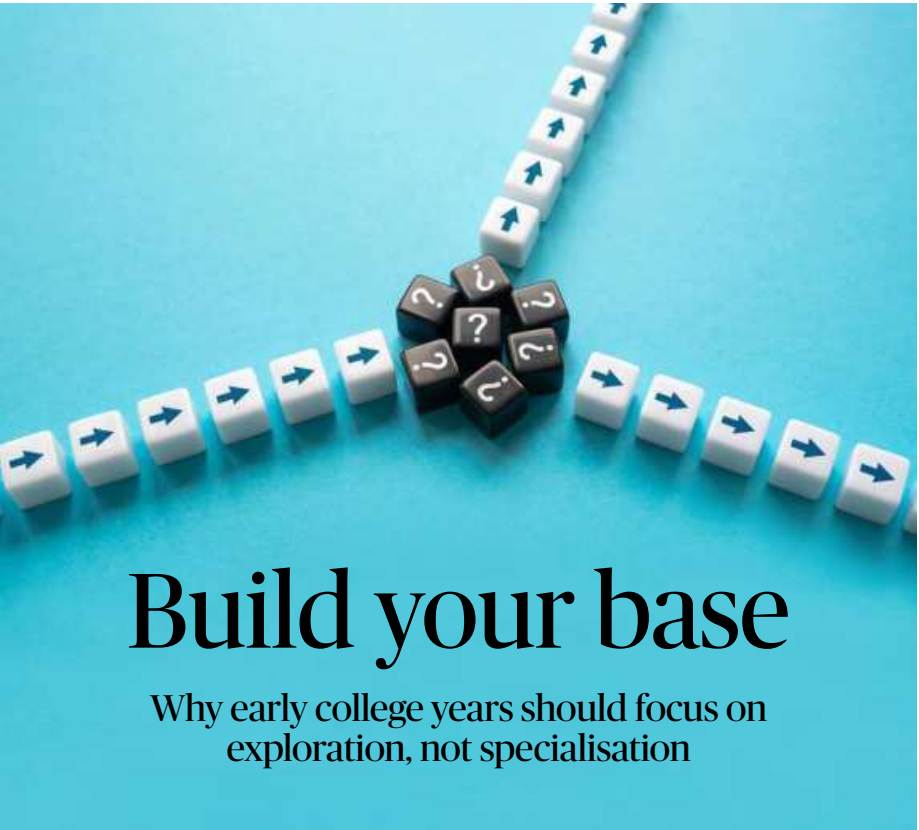
I am in Class 12 and want to prepare for CLAT. I am struggling with time management and am not sure about the right approach. Kanika

Dear Kanika,

CLAT preparation during Class 12 is a balancing act, but your board exams and entrance preparation can complement each other. Follow the 60–40 rule. On weekdays, spend two to three hours on CLAT, reading the newspaper, and practising a specific section. On weekends, spend five to six hours on mock tests and two hours analysing mistakes. Use English and History/ Polity classes to improve reading comprehension and GK.

Take active breaks and switch to CLAT puzzles when tired of Board preparation. Give CLAT your complete focus till December, then shift entirely to Board revisions from January to March.

CLAT tests reading speed and critical thinking. Don't memorise laws; learn to apply principles to facts. Read editorials, understand events, improve reading speed, and strengthen Class 10 Maths. Start taking a mock every 15 days to understand the exam pattern and your baseline. Since CLAT has a -0.25 penalty, focus on improving accuracy



Sudhir K. Routray

Deep intellectual advancement requires a staged academic progression that balances broad exploration with rigorous disciplinary mastery. Initial academic stages should prioritise intellectual pluralism to build essential cognitive versatility and long-term academic resilience.

Students who explore diverse fields early often demonstrate superior interdisciplinary insight during their later graduate research. They effectively recognise vital connections across social systems, policy implications, and rapidly evolving technological infrastructures. This wide intellectual scaffolding ensures that subsequent specialisation remains purposeful, methodologically sophisticated, and contextually aware.

Master's and doctoral programmes provide the focused immersion necessary to produce truly meaningful and original expertise. These advanced

stages demand rigorous analytical depth, theoretical understanding, and highly specific technical domain mastery. Master's programmes emphasise laboratory immersion and applied training, while doctoral tracks extend toward independent research contributions. Specialisation at these levels allows for deep engagement with sophisticated theories and complex modern computational frameworks.

Contemporary research increasingly operates at dynamic disciplinary intersections rather than within traditional, isolated academic silos. Early specialisation without foundational exploration may produce narrow expertise that lacks necessary adaptability in transforming landscapes. Universities seeking global competitiveness must nurture both breadth and depth in a sequential manner. This balanced approach produces graduates capable of addressing complex global challenges through well-informed, innovative expertise.

Indian context

The Indian higher education landscape benefits immensely from exploration-oriented undergraduate programmes that bridge diverse schooling backgrounds. Many students arrive from different state and national boards with differing levels of pedagogical exposure. A broad foundational stage successfully normalises academic readiness across these heterogeneous and complex educational backgrounds.

Universities can introduce interdisciplinary bridge courses to strengthen conceptual coherence among all incoming first-year students. This early exposure to multiple disciplines effectively counters the narrow, exam-centric thinking prevalent in pre-university schooling. Students eventually learn to approach difficult problems through reasoning and critical evaluation rather than simple memorisation.

Flexible major-minor systems enable gradual academic self-discovery through structured and intentional curricular experi-

mentation. Students may sample computing, design, or economics before committing deeply to a specific professional specialisation. This thoughtful exploration reduces academic dissatisfaction and improves student retention through more informed decision-making processes. Faculty mentorship remains critical during these formative years to guide intellectual exploration and responsible scholarly growth.

Graduate education demands rigorous analytical depth, theoretical understanding, and domain-specific technical mastery. Such intensity becomes productive only when learners possess broad intellectual scaffolding from earlier academic stages.

Students who explored multiple fields during undergraduate education often demonstrate superior interdisciplinary insight during graduate research. They recognise connections across computational methods, policy implications, social systems, and technological infrastructures.

This integrative awareness strengthens research originality and innovation capacity within specialised domains.

Indian universities seeking global research competitiveness must nurture both breadth and depth sequentially. Exploration during undergraduate education builds cognitive versatility and academic resilience. Specialisation during Master's and doctoral stages then channels this versatility toward focused scholarly contributions.

This staged academic progression balances curiosity-driven learning with rigorous disciplinary mastery. It finally produces graduates capable of addressing complex national and global challenges through informed expertise.

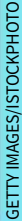
The writer is Dean, Academics, CMR University, Bengaluru.



The answer: "I haven't done anything interesting." No startup. No NGO setup. No national award. No trek across the Himalayas. Just school, coaching, family, books, and the quiet everyday life of a teenager who has been too busy studying to manufacture a compelling story.

Before we get into what to write, it helps to understand what admissions officers are actually looking for. A college essay is not a highlight reel or a summary of your achievements. Nor is it a resume. At its core, it is a conversation. The admissions officer has seen hundreds of transcripts, test scores, and activity lists that day. The essay is when they stop and meet a person.

But the underlying requirement is almost identical: specificity, authenticity, and genuine reflection. Neither requires you to have done something extraordinary; only to have paid attention to your own life.



Tips on writing a good essay for college applications

lead a committee, to share her love of books on a small podcast. Her essay was about the specific texture of her growth: “I was my own worst enemy, I realised. I let everyone influence my decisions, except myself.” This is the

Start with obsessions,

Ask what you have changed your mind about.

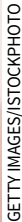
The writer is Associate Professor of Marketing and Finance, Jagan Institute of Management Studies, Rohini

The writer is Founder and CEO, Inomi Learning, a Gurugram-based career and college guidance firm. info@inomi.in

Lecturio, a digital medical education platform integrated into the university's curriculum, helps me revisit topics and our online library offers a treasure trove of e-books and resources that are a lifesaver when I



There are tough days, but I also recognise how much I have learned and how much stronger I have become. The journey of medical school is not just about learning the science of medicine, it is about discovering who you are, what you can handle, and the kind of doctor you hope to become. Medical school is challenging, but looking back at how far I have come, I know it is worth every effort.



Tips to prepare for the Graduate Management Aptitude Test (GMAT)

Though the exam is challenging, preparing for it has become relatively less painful with a pool of accessible resources. Aspirants can use a growing stock of free digital resources, including official practice tools, mock tests, online learning platforms and peer-led study communities, to build a structured preparation strategy at minimal cost.

Effective GMAT preparation starts with under-

Apart from official practice materials, a number of digital platforms such as Jamboree India, Wizako, and Career Launcher provide free resources to support GMAT preparation. Jambo-

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For educational institutions, the implications are profound. Research across universities and schools has repeatedly shown that students who use smartphones late at night report poorer academic performance compared to those who maintain healthier sleep routines. Classroom engagement declines, and they often struggle to ab-

sorb complex concepts. Even when they invest time in studying, the lack of sufficient sleep prevents the brain from properly consolidating the knowledge they acquire.

Educators frequently attribute declining academic performance to factors such as lack of discipline, inadequate study strategies, or poor motivation. However, emerging research suggests that sleep disruption may be an underlying factor that has not received adequate attention. A student who is mentally exhausted is less capable of focusing during lectures, participating in discussions, or retaining information. The result is a cycle of reduced academic performance that cannot be solved simply through stricter study schedules.

The issue extends